SIMATS SCHOOL OF ENGINEERING

SAVEETHA INSTITUTE OF MEDICAL AND TECHNICAL SCIENCES

INFLECTIONAL MORPHOLOGY

How words change form to express grammatical meaning — a foundational concept in Natural Language Processing

PRESENTED BY:

T. Madhu Charan (192472230)

What Is Inflectional Morphology?

Inflectional morphology is the study of how words are modified to express grammatical categories such as tense, number, case, gender, or person, without changing the word's core meaning or its part of speech.

Unlike derivational morphology, inflection never creates a new word; it only produces a different grammatical form of the same lexeme.

EXAMPLE

walk → walks, walked, walking

Each form is still the verb "walk." Only grammatical information — tense or aspect — has been added through inflection.

cat → cats **good → better, best**

Common Inflectional Categories

1

Number

Distinguishes singular and plural forms, such as book and books.

2

Tense

Marks when an action occurs, as in walk versus walked.

3

Case

Shows a noun's grammatical role, seen in pronouns like he and him.

4

Person & Agreement

Verbs change to agree with their subject, as in she runs.

Inflection vs. Derivation

Inflection

Produces different grammatical forms of the same word, keeps the same part of speech, and is generally required by the grammar of the sentence, as in play, plays, and playing.

Derivation

Creates a new word, often with a different part of speech or a substantially different meaning, and is optional rather than grammatically required, as in play to player or happy to happiness.

Why It Matters in NLP

Inflectional morphology directly shapes several core natural language processing tasks. Understanding how words inflect allows systems to reduce vocabulary size, normalize text, and recover the grammatical relationships that meaning depends on.

- **Lemmatization** — Reduces inflected forms such as running and ran back to their dictionary lemma, run.
- **POS Tagging** — Inflectional endings provide strong cues for identifying a word's grammatical category.
- **Machine Translation** — Correct inflection must be generated to match tense, number, and case in the target language.
- **Information Retrieval** — Matching search terms to inflected variants improves recall without losing precision.

Challenges & Takeaways

Languages differ enormously in how much inflection they use. Highly inflected languages such as Finnish or Turkish can attach many suffixes to a single stem, producing a large number of surface forms for one lemma. This makes tokenization, morphological analysis, and data sparsity significant challenges for NLP systems built on such languages.

Handling inflection well — through lemmatizers, morphological analyzers, or subword tokenization — remains essential for building robust language technology across the world's languages.


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form to express grammatical meaning — a foundational concept in Natural Language Processing
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